

**Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action
2026 Candidate Questionnaire**

Candidate Name: Mark Humbert

District / Office being sought: Councilmember, Berkeley Council District 8

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including a San Pablo Specific Plan and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. San Pablo specific plan
- b. Zoning for housing in high-resource commercial areas like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave
- c. Extending 'middle housing' zoning to some parts of the Hills, while balancing fire risk
- d. Other strategies for Berkeley to affirmatively further fair housing

I believe that Berkeley's Housing Element is a critical policy and guiding document for Berkeley's efforts to meet its RHNA, affirmatively further fair housing requirements, and make good on its values of opportunity and inclusion. I believe that the City should strive to deliver on the promises implied by the Housing Element's policies and programs.

With respect to the San Pablo Specific Plan I support significant upzoning to allow for additional homes on this wide and currently underutilized street. I am very pleased that Councilmembers Kesarwani and Taplin are both strongly supportive of this effort and I intend to follow their lead with respect to proposed heights and other development standards.

With regard to zoning for housing in high resource commercial areas, I remain supportive of the Corridors Zoning Update, I am very proud of my work to land the tailored zoning approach, and I'm very thankful that the Planning Commission has formally approved it.

By targeting rezoning to the parcels deemed most feasible by staff and the project team, we can achieve a win-win-win: virtually the same projected capacity for new homes, while also providing certainty to existing small businesses and avoiding disruption of existing pedestrian oriented

retail fabric, and a genuine compromise position that reduces (though doesn't eliminate) the risk of a protracted battle at the ballot box or in the courts.

I will be candid and say that, for a variety of reasons, I do not think that expanding Berkeley's full middle housing zoning to the higher hills is an optimal approach. I think that existing local and State laws already provide for significant (if more modest) additional housing in the hills, through the construction of ADUs/JADUs, duplexes, and lot splits.

I believe that evacuation and density of built material in the hills are legitimate concerns, even if we have to be careful about where they are invoked as a reason to disallow a higher amount of new housing. Also, the lack of access to transit, jobs, stores, and other urban amenities in the higher hills means they are not the ideal place to create additional housing anyway. Of course, future Councils may see this differently, but right now I believe that significant additional housing in the higher hills is not the hill to literally or figuratively die on. And I think there are other lower hanging housing fruits to focus on.

Given the current economics of home building, I think that one of the most important things that Berkeley can do to carry out its Housing Element and affirmatively further fair housing and improve housing affordability is to examine how we can make building easier and more feasible. Berkeley cannot control the macroeconomic factors that are making housing especially difficult to build right now. However, we can take a look at our processes and fees to see how we can reasonably lift obstacles and incentivize more building. Personally, I would like to investigate the potential for pre-approved middle housing plans designed for common Berkeley lot sizes to help encourage more middle housing.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

While good as a guiding document and statement of principles, Berkeley's Climate Action Plan is arguably now somewhat dated and also a bit short on specifics for how we can truly get to the

level of emissions reductions we wish to achieve. As noted by the question, building natural gas use and vehicle emissions remain the two key sources of GHGs in Berkeley.

With respect to natural gas, the City is constrained by judicial decisions that have limited our ability to phase out natural gas by fiat. Thankfully, regional regulations are already serving to push inclusion of alternatives in new buildings and help phase older appliances out by attrition in existing buildings. I support these policies and the City publicizing and offering guidance on them as appropriate. I'm also supportive of Berkeley's local efforts to require energy assessments and a suite of efficiency improvements at the time a property is sold. Over time we may be able to consider strengthening these provisions; however, given severe housing affordability issues I also want to be sure we are not overburdening home buyers, especially first time buyers.

With respect to reducing vehicle emissions we need an all of the above approach. I fully support creating new bike infrastructure, improving public transit, and encouraging more housing near jobs and transit. I also think that Berkeley's efforts to limit and discourage parking in new buildings are a move in the right direction. At the same time, I also think that we should be working to encourage electric vehicles and true ride-sharing/car pooling. Complete phase out of private cars in the time frame we need to act on climate change is simply not feasible. We need to be encouraging electric cars and clean energy to power them as part of a broader, long-term transportation transition.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

Though, of course, I have to give credit to my predecessor Lori Droste for kickstarting the middle housing effort, I believe that the more recent middle housing Council vote, including the density compromise I helped broker, was the single most important vote that Berkeley City Council has taken on housing not just in the past 4 years but arguably the last 40. Undoing the legacy of exclusionary zoning was an enormous win for housing affordability and affirmatively furthering fair housing. I want to build on this vote by adding incentives and removing obstacles for middle housing as much as possible.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

Because Berkeley residents have such a low carbon footprint relative to other parts of the Bay Area, I would argue that building additional housing in Berkeley is the most important environmental issue facing the city, and that therefore our vote on middle housing was also the most important environmental vote Council has taken in recent memory.

But, if forced to choose something else, I would pick Telegraph Multimodal as the most important vote. Given the sheer number of people who travel or could travel along Telegraph, and the potential for new housing along the Avenue, I believe that selecting an alternative with bike and bus lanes was one of our most impactful decisions.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

In light of my previous answers discussing the City's limited control over natural gas use, the most significant area where Berkeley has power to reduce emissions is in the transportation sector. This is why I supported protected bike lanes on Hopkins Street, support additional bike infrastructure elsewhere, and want to see us further improve public transit, to the extent this is within the City's purview. Switching people to active and public transportation is one of the most effective ways to not only reduce emissions, but also reduce other negative environmental and public health impacts of automobile use. At the same time, as I also noted, automobile use is going to remain an important mode of transportation for years to come, so we need to work to reduce emissions from the cars that do and will exist as much as possible.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets?

Pedestrian and bicycle safety was the main motivation for my entry into public service. When a disabled woman was struck and killed by a driver in the Elmwood shortly after I moved to Berkeley, I became involved in efforts to slow traffic and improve safety on Ashby Avenue. This led to my tenure on what is now the Transportation and Infrastructure Commission, The Claremont Elmwood Neighborhood Association, and by extension my run for City Council.

I believe that we need to address pedestrian and cyclist safety through a variety of approaches including but not limited to lower speed limits and automated speed enforcement, adding protected bike infrastructure, using roadway design to slow traffic, crossing signals and improved crosswalk markings, and so much more.

This is why I have fought for safety improvements at Zachary's Corner, along Claremont Avenue (including both quick builds and long-term roadway changes), and protected bike lanes along Hopkins Street.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

Striking the right balance when it comes to on-site inclusionary units, in lieu fees, and the overall levels of both that we require is very difficult and constantly evolving. What worked in Berkeley for the past 15 years or so appears to maybe not be working so well now in light of interest rates and construction costs. On the other hand, we do have some indications that perhaps some projects are starting to move forward. On the other, other hand I believe Berkeley needs to look very carefully at its various fees and requirements to ensure that we have not pushed projects over the cliff of feasibility. I also think there may be an argument for re-examining how we charge our in-lieu fee since moving toward an exclusively square footage based fee has resulted in a return to smaller units being proposed. This is a mixed bag and I think we may want to consider a blended approach where we charge a base cost per unit and then a certain amount per square foot; this might help balance incentives toward small studio and 1-bedroom units and larger multi-bedroom units.